

Community Overview

Community Profile & Demographics

The Township of Montclair is a 6.25 square mile municipality located in Essex County, New Jersey, situated along the Watchung Mountains and serving as both a regional cultural hub and a residential community within the New York metropolitan area

According to recent U.S. Census data, Montclair's population increased from 38,634 in 2020 to 39,873 in 2023, with 15,118 occupied housing units as of 2023. The Township's relatively high population density of approximately 6,380 residents per square mile reflects its compact development pattern and mix of residential and commercial districts.

Montclair is racially and ethnically diverse. As of 2023, the population identifies as approximately 57% White, 18% Black or African American, 11% Hispanic or Latino, 5% Asian, and 8% two or more races. The Township's median household income increased from \$134,308 in 2020 to \$166,765 in 2023, while approximately 6% of residents live below the poverty line

The New Jersey Department of Community Affairs' Municipal Revitalization Index (MRI), which measures economic distress, ranked Montclair 417th out of 564 municipalities in 2023, indicating relatively low levels of economic distress compared to many New Jersey communities.

While Montclair's overall income levels are comparatively high, disparities remain, and certain neighborhoods are identified as overburdened communities under NJDEP criteria. Ensuring equitable access to energy efficiency programs, clean transportation, and renewable energy participation remains a core objective of this Plan.

Housing Characteristics & Energy Implications

Montclair's housing stock plays a significant role in community-wide energy consumption. Of the Township's housing units, approximately 60% are owner-occupied and 40% are renter-occupied

The majority of housing units are one-unit detached homes (8,088 units), while buildings with 20 or more units represent the second-largest category (2,297 units). Importantly, over 9,000 housing units were constructed in 1939 or earlier.

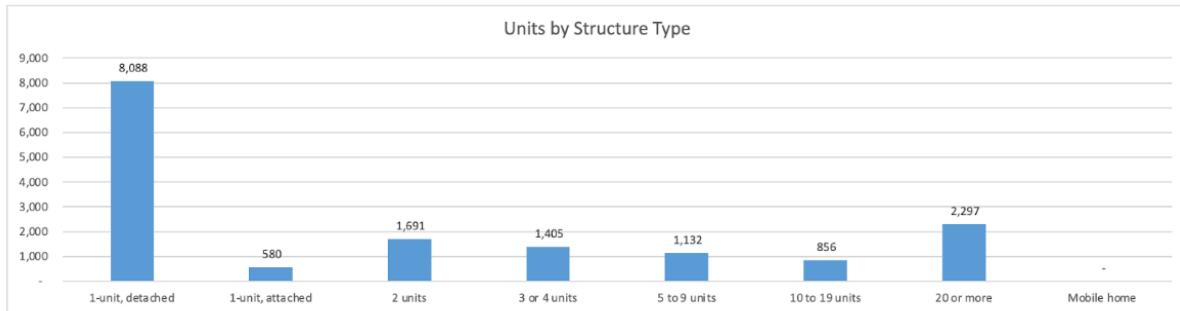
This aging building stock presents both challenges and opportunities:

- Older buildings often lack modern insulation, air sealing, and high-efficiency mechanical systems.
- Deferred maintenance and legacy heating systems contribute to higher energy consumption.

- Historic and architectural preservation considerations may affect retrofit strategies.

At the same time, these buildings represent substantial potential for energy savings through weatherization, electrification, and participation in programs such as Home Performance with ENERGY STAR and Comfort Partners.

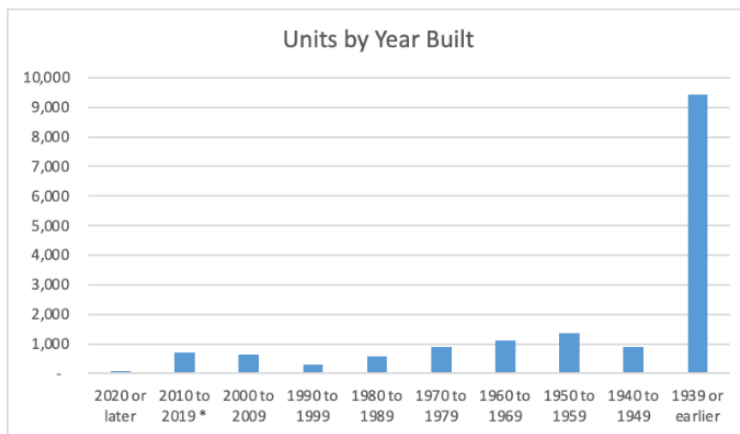
Given the significant renter population, landlord engagement and multifamily-focused energy strategies are critical components of emissions reduction efforts.



Housing Units by Structure Type

Source: Sustainable Jersey. Community Profile Data

Original Data: US Census. 2023. American Community Survey



Housing Units by Year Structure Built

Source: Sustainable Jersey. Community Profile Data

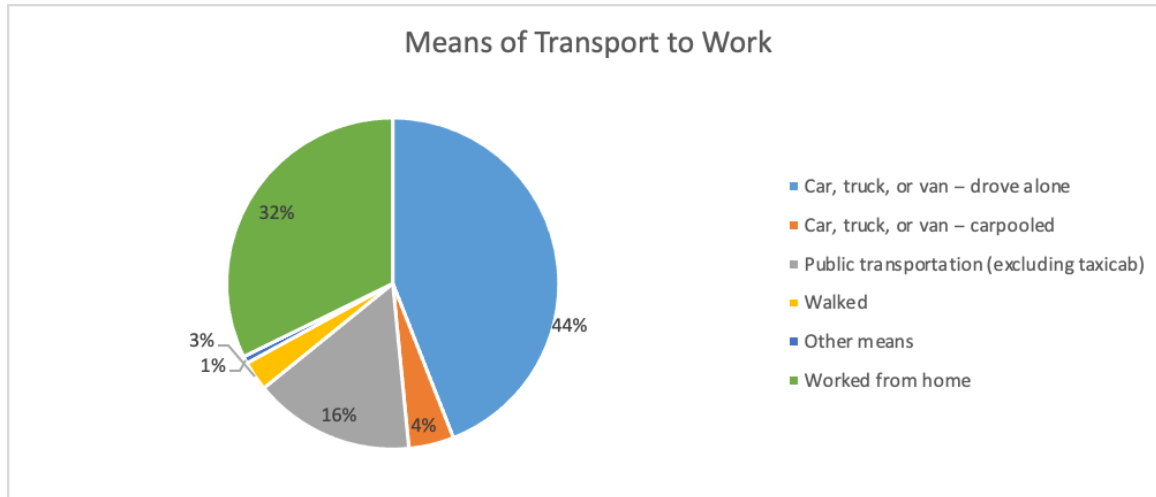
Original Data: US Census. 2023. American Community Survey

Transportation Patterns & Emissions

Transportation is the largest contributor to Montclair's greenhouse gas emissions.

As of 2023:

- 44% of Montclair residents commute by driving alone.
- 16% use public transportation.
- 32% work from home



Means of Transportation to Work.

Source: Sustainable Jersey. Community Profile Data by Municipality

Original Source: 2023 American Communities Survey 5 Year

Additionally, 1,112 households do not have access to a vehicle, underscoring the importance of reliable public transit, walkability, and shared mobility services.

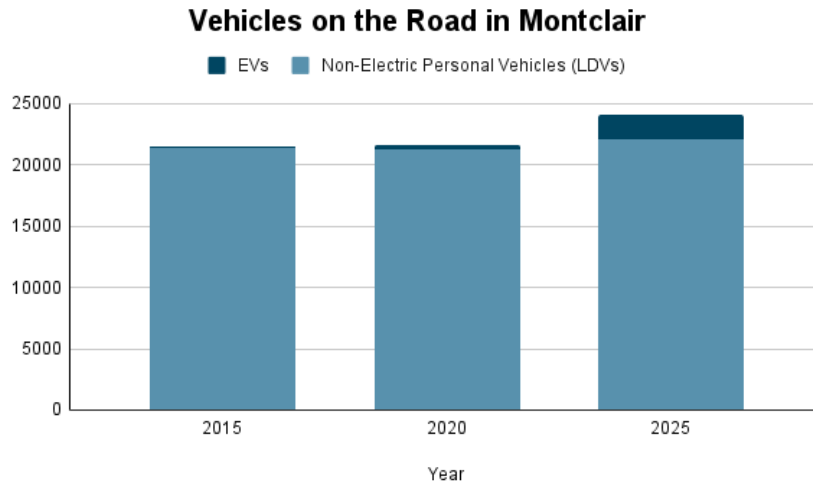
Total Vehicles Available by Occupied Household				
Total Households	No Vehicles Available	1 Vehicle Available	2 Vehicles Available	3 Vehicles Available
15118	1112	6769	5662	1575

Vehicles Available by Occupied Household.

Source: Sustainable Jersey. Community Profile Data by Municipality

Original Source: 2023 American Communities Survey 5 Year

Electric vehicle adoption has increased rapidly in Montclair, growing from 395 registered EVs in 2020 to 1,956 in 2025. This trend reflects both state-level incentives and local policy support for EV infrastructure expansion.



Montclair’s transportation strategy combines:

- Accelerated EV adoption,
- Public charging infrastructure expansion,
- Municipal fleet electrification,
- Traffic safety and shared mobility initiatives,
- Reduction of vehicle miles traveled (VMT).

The Township’s Vision Zero Task Force, Bike Bus program, NJ Transit access, and senior mobility programs further support multimodal transportation and emissions reduction efforts

Alternative Fuel Vehicles Owned by Municipality				
Total AFV	Battery Electric Vehicle	Hybrid Electric Vehicle (non plug in)	Hybrid Electric Vehicle (plug in)	Natural Gas Vehicle
	Light Duty Truck	Light Duty Truck	Light Duty Vehicle	Light Duty Vehicle
9	2	5	1	1

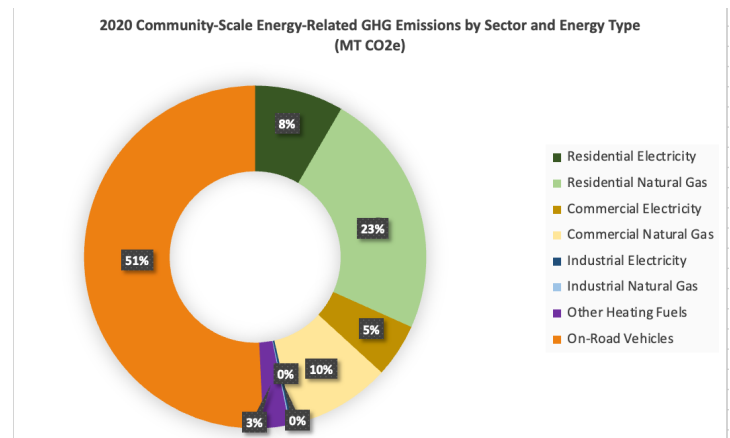
Alternative Fuel Vehicles Owned by Municipality.
Source: Sustainable Jersey. Electric Vehicle Ownership Data
Original Sources: NJDER, Alternative Fuel Vehicle Report, June 2025.

Electricity & Natural Gas Usage

Community-wide electricity and natural gas consumption is primarily associated with buildings, consistent with statewide trends

Sustainable Jersey community-scale greenhouse gas data indicates that in 2020, Montclair emissions were driven by:

MTCO2e by sector	Column Labels	2020
Residential Electricity		28169.73
Residential Natural Gas		78263.76
Commercial Electricity		17041.58
Commercial Natural Gas		32368.61
Industrial Electricity		944.88
Industrial Natural Gas		367.42
Other Heating Fuels		8237
On-Road Vehicles		170480



Community-Scale Greenhouse Gas (GHG) Emissions Data

Source: Sustainable Jersey Data Resources

Original source : Community-Scale GHG Emissions July .24

Natural gas remains a primary heating fuel source across residential and commercial sectors. As climate change contributes to more frequent heat waves and extreme weather events, peak electricity demand for cooling is expected to increase.

Energy efficiency and electrification of buildings are therefore central to Montclair's emissions reduction strategy.

Renewable Energy & Solar Potential

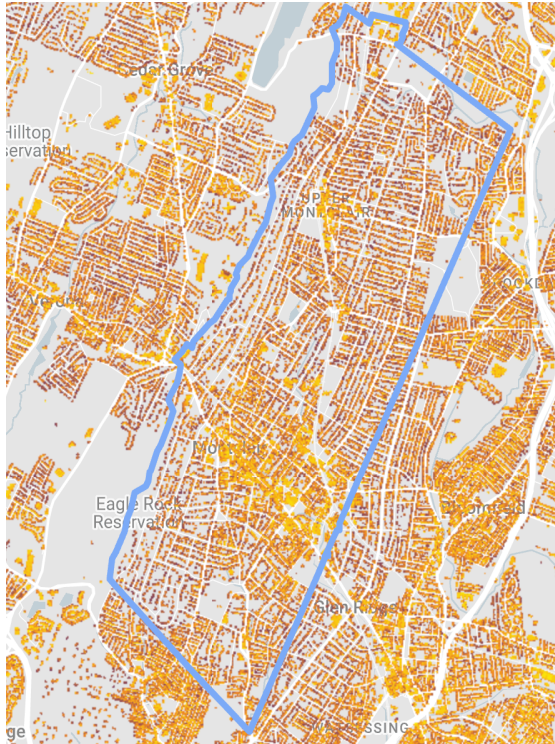
Montclair has made measurable progress in solar deployment. Between 2022 and 2025, 446 solar installations were recorded across residential, nonprofit, and commercial sectors.

A solar feasibility analysis conducted under the NJBPU Community Energy Plan Grant evaluated municipal properties for photovoltaic (PV) potential. While some private properties face shading constraints, available grid capacity and municipal rooftops and parking decks present strong opportunities for continued expansion.

Montclair has:

- Adopted resolutions supporting community solar development,
- Authorized issuance of RFPs for municipal-hosted community solar projects,
- Prioritized low- and moderate-income (LMI) subscription participation

Solar expansion, particularly through community solar models, is critical to expanding access for renters and residents unable to install rooftop systems.



Source: <https://sunroof.withgoogle.com/data-explorer/place/ChIJoSOnRIZVwokRFLIX0GYzn0Q/>

Rooftop Solar: According to a township-wide analysis from Google’s Project Sunroof, Montclair has approximately 8.3 thousand solar-viable roofs, representing about 69% of all analyzed buildings. These rooftops contain an estimated 5 million square feet of usable roof space suitable for solar installations. If fully utilized, these roofs could support approximately 113 MW of solar capacity (DC) and generate about 128,000 MWh of electricity per year.

The median roof in Montclair can support a solar installation of approximately 317 square feet, with an estimated capacity of 7.6 kW DC, capable of producing around 8,200 kWh of electricity annually.

If all viable rooftop solar systems were installed, the resulting clean electricity generation could avoid approximately 83,400 metric tons of CO₂ emissions annually, equivalent to removing about 18,100 passenger vehicles from the road for one year, or the carbon sequestration of approximately 1.4 million tree seedlings grown for 10 years.

*Source: Google Project Sunroof Data Explorer.

Municipal Operations

Although municipal operations represent a smaller share of total community-wide emissions, they serve as a model for best practices and leadership.

Montclair has participated in the Local Government Energy Audit (LGEA) program since 2016, conducting audits of multiple municipal facilities and identifying cost-effective efficiency upgrades.

The Township has also begun transitioning its municipal fleet toward alternative fuel vehicles and is improving fleet benchmarking and efficiency tracking.

By aligning capital planning, fleet replacement schedules, and building upgrades with available NJ Clean Energy Program incentives, Montclair can continue reducing operational emissions while demonstrating scalable solutions for the broader community.

Opportunities & Constraints

Key Opportunities

- High EV adoption growth trajectory
- Strong municipal leadership and sustainability staffing
- Access to NJBPU and NJCEP incentives
- Community solar hosting potential
- Active community engagement networks
- Existing participation in energy efficiency outreach partnerships

Key Constraints

- Aging building stock
 - Split incentives between landlords and tenants
 - Shading constraints on some private properties
 - Funding uncertainties for federal incentive programs
 - Regulatory limitations affecting microgrid feasibility
- Montclair Community Energy Plan
-

Summary

Montclair is a relatively affluent yet socioeconomically diverse municipality with an aging housing stock, growing electric vehicle adoption, strong public transit access, and significant solar expansion potential.

Transportation and buildings represent the largest opportunities for emissions reduction. By focusing on energy efficiency, electrification, renewable energy deployment, and equitable access to programs, Montclair can meaningfully reduce greenhouse gas emissions while improving affordability, resilience, and public health outcomes.

This Community Overview establishes the baseline conditions that inform the strategies and initiatives outlined in the remainder of this Community Energy Plan.

